

Dealing with cyberbullying

There are a number of ways to deal with cyberbullying. The best way for young people to respond to the problem is by blocking bullies on social media and reporting offensive behaviour to the site. Contacting a bullying helpline can also be useful, along with telling family or friends so that they can provide support.

REAL WORLD

Cyberbullying and the law

Cyberbullying isn't a specific criminal offence in most countries, but there are often laws that relate to behaviour or communications that can apply to cyberbullying. As the problem becomes more widespread, police and prosecutors are starting to issue guidelines on these laws. Remarks made on social media may also lead to people being sued for defamation in the civil courts.

Block and report the bully if they are using social media or a public website.

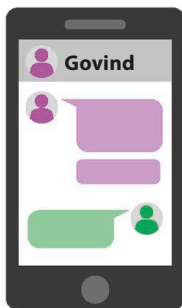
Contact a helpline for young people struggling with issues like bullying to access advice and support.

Save online conversations and screen shots of websites that contain bullying messages or images as evidence.

Tell family members, friends, or teachers, as they can provide support and practical help.

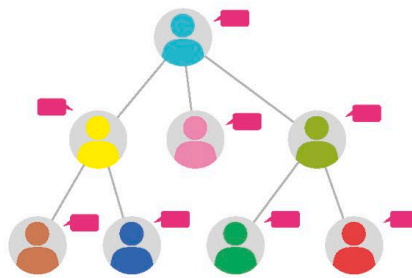
Don't retaliate or reply to the bully as this may simply encourage them to continue.

The ability to make comments anonymously often brings out the worst in people.



△ Evidence

In cases where the bullying isn't anonymous, online messages or incidents are evidence of the bully's behaviour and can be shown to teachers or the police.



△ Thoughtless remarks

Some instances of cyberbullying aren't intentional. A thoughtless remark might unintentionally hurt someone after it is shared by many people.

IN DEPTH

Why do people do it?

There are a variety of reasons why young people may become involved in cyberbullying behaviour. If they have been the victims of bullying, or have problems at home, they may take it out on others. Some see it as a way to increase their popularity at the expense of others. Young people may feel uncomfortable about being involved in a group that's picking on someone, but don't have the confidence to point out and stop the bad behaviour.